Kazakh-speaking man, who had assimilated the Kazakh manners and customs,' wrote one of his admirers. 'Moreover, his handsome dark eyes, beard and cropped hair made him look like an Asian and a Muslim.'[21]

On his second visit, in January 1836, Vitkevitch went openly as a Russian officer, to request the release of several Russian merchants who had been detained by the Amir of Bukhara. On arrival in the caravan city he recorded that he was immediately asked: 'Do you know Iskander? I thought they meant Alexander the Great but they were, in fact, talking of Alexander Burnes.' This early indication of British influence did not stop Vitkevitch almost immediately trying to reverse it, and it took him only a couple of weeks to uncover the intelligence network that Burnes had established in order to send news back to India: 'The British have their man in Bukhara,' Vitkevitch soon reported to St Petersburg.

> He is a Kashmiri called Nizamuddin and has been living in Bukhara for four years now under the pretext of trade . . . He is a very clever man, rubs shoulders with everyone and entertains the Bukharan noblemen; at least once a week he sends letters with secret messengers to Kabul, to the Englishman Masson who passes them on. The most curious thing is that Dost Mohammed is aware of Masson's activities; the Khan has even intercepted his letters but leaves the spy alone, saying: one man cannot harm me. Apparently, Dost Mohammed does not want to incur their displeasure out of respect to Europeans in general, and he tolerates Masson too. This man lives in Kabul under the pretext of looking for ancient coins.

Nizamuddin had a kinsman in Bukhara, added Vitkevitch,

> who does all the paperwork for him. They have taken lodgings, rather luxurious by local standards, in Koosh Begee's [chamberlain]caravansarai, where they entertain the nobility; Nizamuddin dresses in fine clothes and is a man of rare physical beauty; his companion is very clever if unseemly and behaves as a subordinate although it is obvious that he is the one who runs the affairs. They receive their money from Indian bankers. Nizamuddin sought my acquaintance as soon as I arrived and asked me many questions: about Novo-Alexandrovsk, the New Line, our relations with Khiva, etc. Having been forewarned, I did not give him any definite answers. All the same, he sent a letter to Kabul the very next day.[22]

It was on this second visit to Bukhara that Vitkevitch had an extraordinary break. By chance, his visit coincided with that of an Afghan emissary, Mirza Hussein Ali, who had been sent by Dost Mohammad Khan on a mission to Tsar Nicholas. After defeating Shah Shuja outside Kandahar in 1834, Dost Mohammad had discovered letters from Wade encouraging the Afghan chiefs to support the restoration of the Sadozai monarchy with Shuja at the helm. Britain's secret aid for the Shah had come as a great